



During the period known as the “phoney war,” preparations for conflict in suburban Britain often seemed bizarre, with no real enemy to fire at.

a military alliance with the Soviet Union—a country they disliked and distrusted. No one anticipated a deal between Hitler and the Soviet leader Joseph Stalin, but on August 23 the Soviet and German foreign ministers, Vyacheslav Molotov (1890–1986) and Joachim von Ribbentrop (1893–1946), signed a nonaggression treaty, known as the **Molotov–Ribbentrop Pact**, which included a provision to divide Poland between them.

German forces invaded Poland on September 1. Two days later, unable to escape their commitment to the Poles, the **British and French governments declared war on Germany**. Australia, New Zealand, Canada, and South Africa followed. Britain brought India into the war without consulting its elected representatives, while **Ireland** and the **US** declared their **neutrality**. Much to Hitler’s annoyance, Italy also declared

Finnish Rifle

The Finnish Lahti anti-tank rifle was used against the Soviets during the Winter War, which began with the Russian invasion of Finland.



itself neutral. The war was greeted by all countries with fear and resignation. There were no cheering crowds in Berlin, London, or Paris.

The **destruction of Poland** was achieved with breathtaking speed. German troops reached the outskirts of Warsaw within a week. The Poles fought with courage and tenacity—Germany sustained more than 40,000 casualties—but once Soviet troops moved in from the east all was lost. **Warsaw surrendered** on September 28, and the fighting stopped a week later. Dividing the country between them, the Soviets and Nazis set about imprisoning and massacring Poles in large numbers.

Throughout the autumn the Germans began confining Poland’s Jews to **ghettos**, a major step toward the Holocaust (see 1942). Hitler had already signed an order in Germany at the start of the war for the killing of people with incurable mental disabilities. Over **70,000 German mental patients were murdered** by lethal injections or gassing, before the operation was suspended in August 1941.

With Poland crushed, the Western democracies entered the period known as the “**phoney war**.” After the fall of Poland the British and French rejected a peace offer from Hitler, but the troops they assembled in France remained passive. The lack of military action was a relief to the British and French governments. German air attacks and massive civilian casualties had been expected, but did not occur.

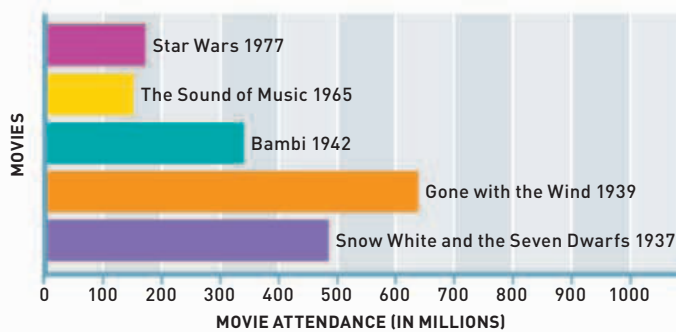
The only dramatic action in Britain’s war against Germany was at sea. In October, the German Navy’s U-boat *U-47* penetrated the defenses of Britain’s main naval base at Scapa Flow, in the Orkney Islands off Scotland, and **sank the battleship *Royal Oak***. British morale was

raised two months later when the German battleship ***Graf Spee*** was driven by British cruisers to take refuge in the neutral port of Montevideo in Uruguay, where the Germans scuttled it.

At the end of November, the **Soviet Union launched an attack on Finland**. The **Winter War** revealed severe deficiencies in the organization, equipment, and leadership of the Soviet Red Army. By the end of the year, the Finns still held their Mannerheim Line defenses, and the Soviets had suffered heavy losses.

Movie attendance

Movies of the late 1930s achieved extraordinary ticket sales. Around 80 million movie tickets were sold in the US every week.



Remaining neutral, the US seemed a world away from the blacked-out cities of Europe. The **New York World’s Fair**, opened in April, taking “The World of Tomorrow” as its theme. Around 44 million visitors came to see such novelties as nylon stockings and color photography.

Hollywood was enjoying a **golden era**, with classic releases including *Gone With the Wind*, *The Wizard of Oz*, and *Stagecoach*. Grand picture palaces, some of which could accommodate more than 4,000 customers, were filled. The American economy was poised for a decisive upturn as an **amendment to the Neutrality Act** allowed US factories to equip the British and French war effort.



Off to see the Wizard
Julie Garland played Dorothy in the 1939 movie The Wizard of Oz—perfect fantasy entertainment for hard and dangerous times.

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THE NUMBER OF DAYS GERMANY TOOK TO OVERRUN POLAND

